



Government of Nepal
National Reconstruction Authority



Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform
Primary Funded by: DFID & CRS

WEBINAR #2

IMPACT of COVID-19 on Post-Earthquake Recovery and Reconstruction in Nepal and the way forward

14th May 2020



PANELISTS

- Dr. **Chandra Bahadur Shrestha**; Executive Member, NRA
- Ms. **Amanda Duff**; Senior Reconstruction Advisor, DFID Nepal
- Mr. **Surya Narayan Shrestha**; Executive Director, NSET
- Ms. **Shobhana Pradhan**; Country Director, BBC Media Action

*Link to complete webinar recording [here](#).

KEY POINTS FROM HRRP PRESENTATION ON IMPACT OF COVID19 ON POST-EARTHQUAKE RECOVERY AND RECONSTRUCTION IN NEPAL AND THE WAY FORWARD

*Link to presentation [here](#).

- COVID19 impact on reconstruction was conducted by HRRP. Opinion of various stakeholders was collected which was the basis for proposing some of the strategies. The study used mixed methods: both qualitative and quantitative. Sample size was 745. Respondents were beneficiaries, mobile masons, technical staff, DLPIU, CLPIU, donors and Partner Organization (PO)s.
- 56% reported that they have reconstructed, 27% - reconstruction ongoing and 16% not started.
- 34% with ongoing construction were continuing reconstruction during lockdown.
- Respondents suggested 3-6 month will be required to catch up the elapsed time.
- 33% municipalities reported that reconstruction is still ongoing, especially in rural areas with the use of local materials.
- 58% municipalities said people are approaching for information especially on tranche updates. Some other requirements were information on technical support, information on new beneficiary and decision on grievance.
- Only 16% of technical staff were carrying out inspection in the field.
- 45% masons were working in duty station and 55% went back to hometowns.
- 50% POs reported activities halted, others have some activities continuing and some have reduced targets.
- DLPIU reported that 85% field visits have halted due to COVID-19.
- DLPIU suggested refresher training, visits to Palikas to prepare action plan as per need.

- Support expected from beneficiaries: tranche release, financial support, deadline extension, inspection and lockdown relaxation.
- Recommendations: ensure supply of construction materials, track tranche disbursement, extend tranche deadline, continue inspection, conduct training on COVID 19 safety protocol on sites, improve communication and engage local masons.
- In addition, support vulnerable households, SOP from NRA to resume ongoing critical reconstruction, waive or subsidize interest on reconstruction loans, fast-track caseload before monsoon (last point was incomplete).
- Donors/partners to realign program priorities.
- Example: Laxmi Maya Shrestha, 73 years old, in Likhu GP, Okhaldhunga started her reconstruction work on 10 May 2020 during lockdown, showing the potential to reconstruct in this period as well.

**Mr. Sushil Gyewali**

CEO

NRA

- Even under lockdown is good news. Recommendations from the study and panelists are useful.
- We are certainly considering extending of the deadline. However, as it is not clear until when will it will calm down, we could not take decision. Once that happens, we will take appropriate decision. at Most probably the first tranche will be extended up to 15 July 2020, second installment up to January 2021 third up to April 2021. But it is too early to say. Decision to be made by the steering committee after relaxation of lock down scenario.
- With respect to grievance we are in the final stage. We will complete it in a week. Households who are not content with NRA's decision, will be able to take Appellate Committee route for addressing their concern.
- We will focus on the vulnerable Households. 50000 topup has been decided and instructions have been sent to DLPIU at local level.
- 800 mobile masons and 250 social mobilizers will be deployed with the main purpose of supporting vulnerable beneficiaries.
- It may not be wise to visit the field right now for engineers. Certain numbers are supporting reconstruction in villages but cannot be possible on a larger scale. We can plan when modalities of lockdown change.
- It will be good to prepare we for the long run as this will not be ending very soon
- Good to have guidelines on safety measures from the perspective of different stakeholders. HRRP and NSET to Prevention Control Measures and Guidelines for construction site, transport of materials.
- Requested for suggestions on issues of supply chain and material availability.

- Support to reconstruction will be support to overall economy.
- Approximately 83% have received second tranche and 72% have received 3rd tranche.
- We must focus on local governments.
- Labour force and migrant workers. Need to create jobs in urban areas, including providing training. Need to see the budget which we will know soon, in about 15 days.
- Thank you to all for this initiative.



Mr. Ramkrishna Sapkota

Secretary
NRA

The survey findings further confirmed our own information, how can we ensure that people's safety is maintained? At the same time, how can we expedite tranche disbursement, ensure people have materials and access to labor? These are important areas to probe. In addition, how can we properly communicate with different stakeholders? All 200+ POs have been coordinated with HRRP. Thank you to HRRP. The survey is very relevant, and findings are helpful, we will take decisions accordingly in the days to come.

INSIGHT FROM PANELISTS



Dr. Chandra B. Shrestha
Executive Member
NRA

- Grateful to HRRP and panelists for the webinar and unplugging the issues we are facing. The scenario planning technique may be instrumental to tackle with volatile situation.
- Increased inflow of workers from abroad can be positive for reconstruction. However deprivation of income, affordability etc. are very critical issues.
- Donors and NGOs will be occupied repairing their own economies, we will have less resources from abroad. Govt. expenditure will also be constrained. We will have to optimize within a number of constraints.
- The budget will be reflected very soon and then will inform the realities in our hands.

Positive notes:

- Vulnerable groups: working procedure is finalized and budget secured. The vulnerable beneficiaries can receive additional 50,000 NPR. The ones who have finished housing will not receive this top up, because they have had the ability to rebuild. NRA only targets those who are not being able to reconstruct. They have lined up human resources: masons, NRA engineers and social mobilizers for vulnerable households.
- In terms of time for reconstruction, we will have a steering committee meeting and decide about the tranche extension for reconstruction
- 5000 grievances remaining which will be handled in the next week or so. Those who are still not content, can go to the Appellate Committee.
- Request to development partners: appeal to work together to raise awareness in 32 districts where construction has been impaired. We will develop a policy which will be widely disseminated through various communication mediums on how to be safe at the construction sites.

- One of the most important aspects is coordination with local governments. We need to collaborate directly with the local government to be able to proceed.

INSIGHT FROM PANELISTS



Ms. Amanda Duff
Sr. Reconst. Advisor
DFID Nepal

- COVID-19 is a public health crisis, and different compared to a natural disaster. However, there are lots of overlaps between the 2 recovery processes. As a reconstruction committee we have a lot to offer to respond to COVID-19.
- Two sets of impacts: primary impacts linked to illness itself, such as spread, contain and manage. We won't get into that. The area of impact of interest to us are secondary impacts. We are on common ground in understanding those impacts; caused by a mix of illness, isolation, and impacts of restrictions. COVID19 is having a massive impact on economies across the world.
- Remittances have stopped and many have returned to Nepal and are looking for jobs in these hard times. Lockdown has meant loss of jobs, affecting daily wage earners. Small businesses are struggling and there are big interruptions on supply chains.
- The vulnerable could possibly be pushed further into vulnerability and those on brink of building up could be pushed into vulnerability as well.
- We need to look at what we have learnt along the way through reconstruction.
- We must keep the momentum going, helping people build homes is a solid first step to help them be less vulnerable.
- We have learnt what an important party local government play. That sort of link to Gaupalikas and working at grassroots level through them has potential. The sort of info the palikas have obtained through reconstruction process such as on vulnerability provides a baseline that could be used to measure how things are improving.
- We have learnt through the earthquake recovery that we must think not just about housing, we need to think about livelihoods and longer-term recovery as well. Construction can be a good way of injecting resources into local economy and provide transferable skills.

- We should ask ourselves: How do we restart? To keep it safe to return to construction. Construction sector requires supply chains to be intact and a labour force. We need to look at what data we have on this -- what are the disruptions in the supply chains and how to get it working. How do people engage in supply chains without putting people at risk?
- How do we make the workplace safe? How do people get in and out of site? What provisions do they need to make such as handwashing and protective clothing?
- How do we think of communicating information to people who need to know this? How do we distill out a best practice as a reconstruction community?

INSIGHT FROM PANELISTS



Mr. Surya N. Shrestha
Executive Director
NSET

- At the global and country level, we hear that many in urban areas are returning to rural areas. With this happening, construction pattern will also change. Example: not just in reconstruction but also in normal construction in rural areas, which may increase. So, we need to conduct a survey to see if the construction in rural areas will go up due to COVID19. Then we will need a different strategy for increased construction. If it does, the typology of construction will also change and we will need new guidelines for this, for example more timber supply will be required and trainings for masons will need to increase.
- Survey from HRRP also suggests continuity of material supply, municipalities, mayors etc. say that they have reserve materials, but the real issue is that vendors will increase cost of materials. NRA and concerned departments should be able to contain price increase and ensure continued supply.
- Availability of labour force: on one hand we will have a lot of labour force in rural areas and on the other there may be shortage of labour force in urban areas. NRA will need strategy for new labour force for both rural and urban
- Continuity of technical assistance: many of the technical support staff have also travelled, hence availability of technical support is an issue in villages.
- Pumping in money due to COVID in rural areas will help in reviving the economy and generating employment. NRA, CTVET (Council for Technical Education and Vocational Training) etc. need to work on this.
- How can the NRA ensure momentum for reconstruction?
- They should develop guidelines and SOP on how to resume and how to ensure health and safety of those involved. Specific guidelines for material supply, for banks, for DLPIU and CLPIU for inspection guidelines etc. should be developed NRA should work with NDRRMA and Ministry of Health and Population Control.

INSIGHT FROM PANELISTS



Ms. Sobhana Pradhan
Country Director
BBC Media Action

- Focus on limitations and challenges, and what media can potentially address?
- Challenges around communicating to communities. There is a gap between what we know and what is happening in the field. Inform them of guidelines, have robust emergency plans and help them to think of details thoroughly.
- Encouraging innovative ideas. Before designing communication, we need to discuss what challenges we face in designing communication
 - **Mistake #1:** skimping on audience research. One size does not fit all. Understand how people respond to different risks, take into account socio-political factors. Understand barriers and motivators before designing communication
 - **Mistake #2:** Create a snazzy product with no strategy for change.
 - **Mistake #3:** Avoid Conversation. If we don't get people to talk and we don't discuss risk reduction and response, our impact will be limited. How to earn a livelihood? How to raise money for reconstruction? The media can really prompt conversations for people to make decisions. Inclusive public dialogue can be encouraged through outreach and social media.
- HRRP's presentation does a good job at understanding people's perception.
- In this age, misinformation spreads at speed and scale. This has been a challenge long before COVID19. Everyone has a responsibility here, experts, authorities and media. Media must maintain high editorial standards and be critical of information shared.
- Finally, all organizations are recognizing the importance of communication, real need for agencies to work together.

Q&A

Safe Construction and Infection Prevention Control Measures

Q: What is the NRA considering in terms of safeguarding field staff's health and safety?

A: *Yes, we will develop safety protocol for ensuring field staff health and safety.*

Q: Are there any guidelines/protocols developed by NRA to protect construction workers from COVID infection?

A: *Request to development partners: appeal to work together to raise awareness in all 32 districts. HRRP and NSET has been directed to start working on the Prevention and Control Guidelines for construction work including dissemination plan.*

Media and Communication

Q: How can the media play a role to positively influence the fear in COVID19 affected communities? What is the position of BBC Action Media in this context?

A: *Media is critical in the Covid-19 response, providing unique access to people otherwise cut off from support due to movement restrictions, physical distancing strategies and the 'shielding' of the most vulnerable. Media can do this at scale.*

These days we are seeing many instances of communities and individuals in Nepal influenced by a lot of misinformation and disinformation related to Covid-19. Understandably, these rumours would tend to create confusion and sometimes panic amongst communities. However, it is really important that trusted media such as the BBC should not just ignore the misinformation and disinformation but provide correct and clear information to counter this false information. This is one of the initiatives that BBC Media Action has been doing since early this year. Some examples are messaging on a number of media platforms, bringing in experts to speak about these issues and simplifying 'technical terminologies in a language that is understandable and working with local media partners in addressing the challenges around misinformation and disinformation.

When providing the information especially for communities in rural areas, it is important ensure that the information is provided in that is adapted to their language and comprehension needs, and reality of their lives are less able to make informed decisions for prevention and treatment, including women, children, ethnic minorities, people with disabilities and those in remote areas.

Our work in this area will focus on providing information to communities focused on increasing knowledge (including debunking rumours), supporting psychosocial wellbeing, connecting people, prompting discussion, and motivating people to act. This can help people make decisions about taking care of themselves and seeking support when it is available.

Funding and Priorities

Q: There have been large diversion of funds from donor agencies. Can you please elaborate? Has there been changes in the priorities of support?

A: This is an assumption based on the impact of pandemic to all countries when everybody has to mend their own house. But we are confident that the existing commitment will be fulfilled but difficulties could be for the new commitments.

Q: How can we address the fact that there is no effective livelihood recovery program by donor agencies?

A: There are many interventions on livelihoods both as part of earthquake recovery as well as ongoing development initiatives. There is lots of evidence and work over the years to see what works, In DFID's post-earthquake recovery, we are working on smaller livelihoods initiatives but also with private sector on helping small and medium enterprises/businesses to grow and access finance and policies that will help sustain them in the long run.

Continuation of regular reconstruction work

Q: What is the procedure of field monitoring during lockdown?

A: We have been developing a health and safety protocol under which we will orient our engineers and other employees. It is in progress now.

Q: POs have stopped work in some districts based on directive from district authority, what can be done about this?

Q: Due to COVID19 lockdown, organizations are not able to resume the reconstruction work as they are unable to reach the field. In this context how is NRA planning to support/facilitate organizations so that they can resume work and complete it before monsoon starts?

A: On one hand we will be working for generating awareness among all stakeholders on the other hand we will be constantly in touch with district authorities for exploring possibilities to open the reconstruction activities again.

Q: Can the NRA share what is the status of disbursement of assistance by India and has it been impacted by the current border disputes?

A: *It is almost resolved. Other issues are in the process of finalization.*

Q: Retrofit work remains a challenge to this day. Even now, some retrofit beneficiaries are found to be expecting full beneficiaries. What is the role and plan of NRA in completing the retrofit work on time? And what could be the role of local government in accomplishing this task?

A: *We will be providing technical assistance to all retrofit beneficiaries within our constraints. They will have also option to change their status from partial to full beneficiary. The local government can also play some role by expediting the process.*

Q: As the NRA timeline is up to Dec 2020, what is the current progress on Monasteries reconstruction, shouldn't we be providing more priorities to community reconstruction? Due to COVID situation, these might not be completed by the NRA timeline, what will be the NRA's plan to complete this?

A: *The activities which cannot be concluded will be handed over to the concerned generic line agency.*

COVID-19 and its indirect impact

Q: The materials and workforce are unavailable for ongoing recovery and reconstruction; the supply chain is broken and will take significant time to gain momentum. What is your suggestion for implementing partners that are working in fixed timeframes and approved targets?

A: *After normalization of the situation, all supply chain will be reactivated. NRA can work to facilitate administrative blockages if required on case to case basis. We will remain flexible in terms of time frame at least the affected duration by COVID-19.*

NRA policies and procedures

Q: What are the chances that the tranche deadline will be extended?

A: *Issues seen are deadline of tranche: because of COVID19 we are certainly thinking of extending the deadline, at the moment we do not know duration of COVID and of NRA, Most probably the first tranche will be extended up to July 2020, second installment up to January 2021, third up to April 2021. But it is too early to say. Decision to be made by the steering committee after relaxation of lock down scenario.*

Q: Project agreement of some organizations with the NRA has been completed and due to project constraints, it cannot be extended. Some beneficiaries have not received all tranches or are non-compliant. How can the organization handover these cases to NRA so that after achieving compliance and completion they may receive the tranches?

A: *We will take decision case by case basis after considering all factors.*

Q: In the current circumstances, will the international conference be organized as scheduled?

A: *As it stands now, we are still aiming for Nov. 2020 but in which form, how will depend on the situation.*

Q: As we know Prime minister jobless incentive has been given to local authorities, Can NRA lobby with the PM's office or Local authority to use that to pay laborers and people to complete reconstruction of vulnerable beneficiaries? Due to this COVID many people have gathered in their village.

A: *Perhaps not direct lobbying but we are hopeful that the common sense will prevail.*

Q: Considering the delay caused by COVID19, Will the NRA timeline be extended?

A: *It will depend on the Steering Committee's decision. Irrespective to the extension, Government of Nepal(GoN) will make appropriate arrangement to conclude all NRA activities.*

Q: It is an opportunity for the NRA to lead the recovery process (both socio-economic and reconstruction) to address COVID-19 impact in earthquake affected districts. So how do you think the NRA can work with different ministries to pull together resources and lead as a leading organization? Do you think this is possible?

A: *As our duration is approaching to an end, we do not have luxury to become ambitious. However, whatever could be possible and whatever is sensible, we will make attempt to undertake.*

Vulnerability

Vulnerable groups: working procedure and budget has been developed. The vulnerable beneficiaries can receive additional 50,000 NPR. The ones who have finished housing will not receive this top up, because they have had the ability to rebuild, they will only target those who are not being able to reconstruct. They have lined up human resources: masons, NRA engineers and social mobilizers for vulnerable groups.

Q: Many HH will become vulnerable due to lack of income, how will we address the new vulnerabilities?

A: *The appropriate GoN agency will take care of this but not NRA.*

Q: Has the name list been finalized for the vulnerable top up support?

A: *We could not receive revised list from the Municipalities for which we will mobilize our mason, social mobiliser and engineer for ascertaining the status of the vulnerable household.*

Q: NRA decided to top-up 50k support to most vulnerable beneficiaries recently. Is the support for ALL most vulnerable beneficiaries or are there any conditions attached to it? Many of the vulnerable households have taken loans to construct houses, which is to meet the NRA deadline. They are still in debt and with COVID impacting their livelihood puts them in great threat of not being able to repay loans. With constraints for accessing the top-up support, as they had taken risks to construct houses, will exclude them from their entitlement and much needed support at this time. How is the NRA looking to support those households, isn't those households will be more vulnerable due to debt in this situation?

A: *We wanted to target vulnerable households. The household which constructed already in interpreted as capable household with adequate social capital. NRA's decision was based on leave no behind!*

Q: Recent NRA's decision excludes the vulnerable households who had received third tranche be eligible for the top-up support. These vulnerable households have taken loans to complete the house, with the hope that they will receive top-up support. As the decision excludes them from receiving the promised additional support, it is like a punishment for them for taking loans and risk to construct the house and deprives them from their entitlement.

A: *We wanted to target vulnerable households. The household which constructed already in interpreted as capable household with adequate social capital. NRA's decision was based on leave no behind!*

Preparation and Planning

Q: How is preparedness planning for the upcoming monsoon season being adapted as collective evacuation shelters may not be the preferred solution during this pandemic? Would this be an incentive to increase safer housing quicker than ever?

A: *For this, NDRRMA has been planning appropriately.*

Q: What kind of additional support, if any, are the LGs providing for reconstructions efforts? And how are they managing the trade-offs with COVID-related support?

A: It is not clear and obvious so far. But we will realize this after commencing our operation.

Q: What will be the scenario for reconstruction if any of the Rural Municipalities are severely hit by COVID19? Does the NRA or any government entity have a plan for it?

A: GoN will come up with appropriate plan to handle that situation.

Urban Reconstruction

Q: Through the different waves of lockdowns we will go through, what differences do you perceive in developing reconstruction support in urban areas compared to rural areas?

A: *We may not come up with additional instruments. We will put our efforts to make our existing efforts effective.*

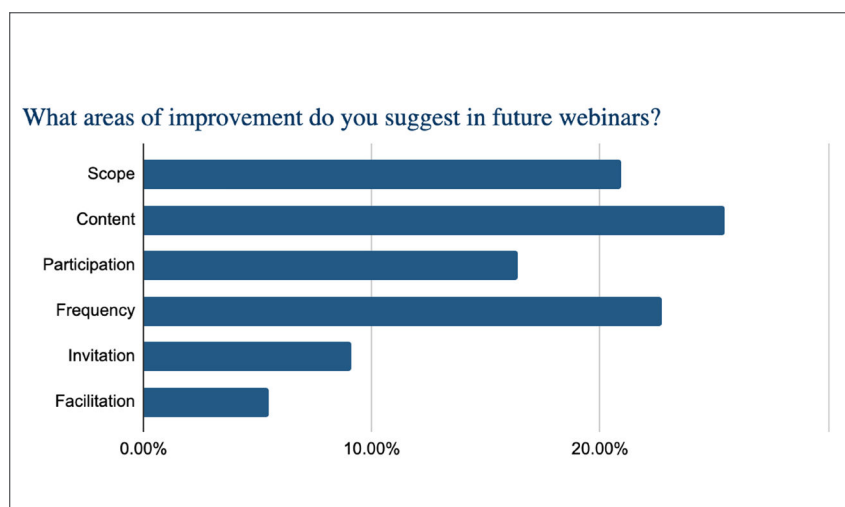
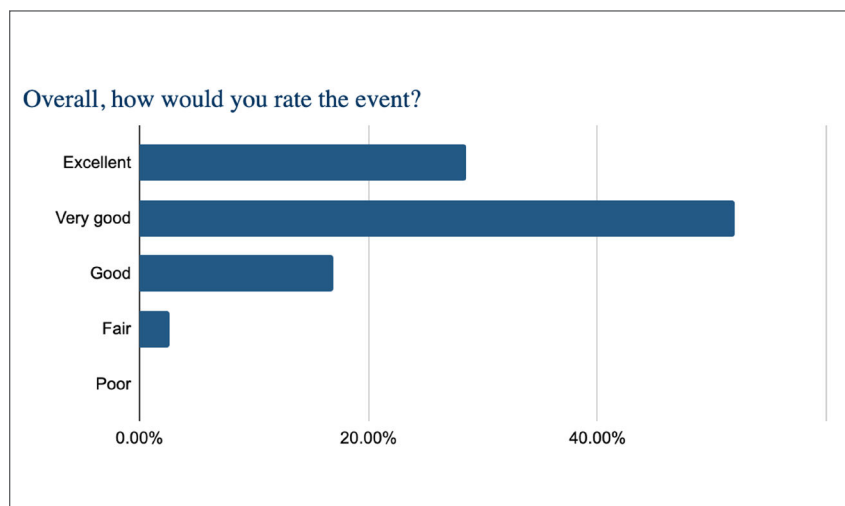
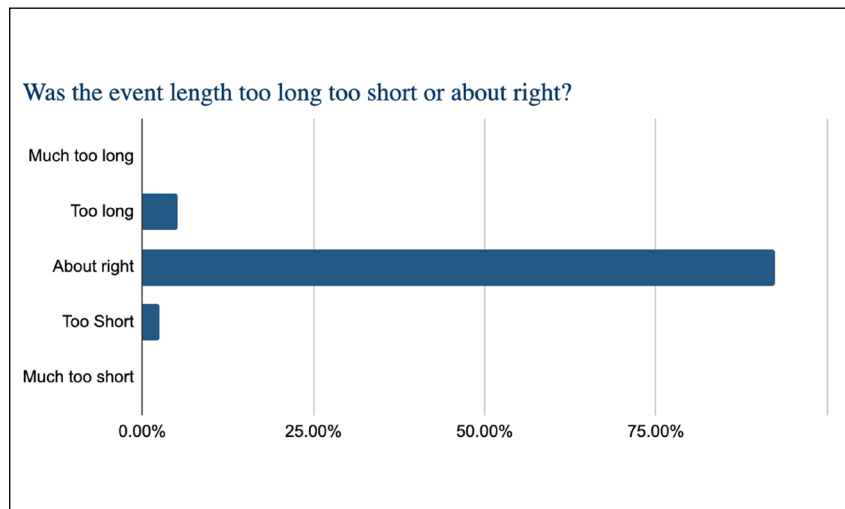
Answer in one word: what COVID-19 impacted most in post earthquake reconstruction?

Mentimeter



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FEEDBACK RECEIVED



AGENDA

15:00 - 15:05	Welcome and introduction to Webinar Theme (5 min)
15:05 - 15:15	HRRP Presentation (10 min)
15:15 - 15:20	Q & A on the presentation
15:20 - 15:50	Panel discussion (5 min for each panelist) - What are the key issues, impacts and responses linked with COVID-19 and the recovery and reconstruction efforts in Nepal? - How can we ensure continued momentum on reconstruction activities to ensure recovery efforts of the past 5 years aren't reversed and there is a comprehensive plan going forward in addressing needs of those that are at risk of being left behind?
15:50 - 16:15	Discussion and Q&A Opinions on current reconstruction priorities (25 min) - What are the arising priority actions and commitments? - What are the recommendations for the way forward?
16:15 - 16:20	Remarks by NRA Secretary, Mr. Ramkrishna Sapkota (5 min)
16:20 - 16:30	CEO, Mr. Sushil Gyewali, NRA - Final Remarks and closing (10 min)